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Jane Monheit

Vocalist Jane Monheit was born in Oakdale, NY on November 3, 1977. She graduated from the Manhattan School of Music and was a finalist in the 1998 Thelonious Monk Jazz Institute vocal competition. Her most recent recording is "Home" on the Emarcy/Universal label.

Jane was interviewed in Clinton, NY, on August 20, 2010, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe, off camera, and we are at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Jane Monheit as my guest for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

JM: Well thanks for having me.

MR: I've been looking forward to talking to you, and I've been sort of following your career because I know your husband and your father-in-law quite well.

JM: Of course.

MR: It's been about ten years since your first CD? Is that right?

JM: Yeah. It came out in May of 2000 my first record, so yeah, it's been ten years.

MR: And I was looking at your list and it's pretty consistent. You have about a CD almost every year.

JM: Yeah, yeah. There've been a couple of longer breaks, a year and a half or so here and there, depending on what's going on during times when there was intense touring and stuff like that you know. There was a longer space between "Surrender" and the "Lovers and Dreamers and Me" because I had a baby.

MR: Oh no kidding.

JM: Well I had it while we were making "Lovers and Dreamers and Me." It — him. But yeah, it depends. It's been eight studio albums and two DVDs in ten years, and two "best of" records which is totally weird at 32, I mean two "best of's" at 32.

MR: Yeah. Now was that your — I want to spend a little time seeing if I can get a handle on how the music business works these days — not that I ever really knew. But I get a lot of students asking me now, and I don't really know.

JM: It changes constantly. No one's got a real handle on it now. If they did the record companies would be in better shape.

MR: Well your first record, you got hooked up with Joel Dorn, the producer. What was he like, first of all?

JM: He was the most amazing person ever. You know, he and I were very close. Joel sort of had a team of guys that he liked to work with all the time, a bunch of musicians. And we were sort of like his little club. And I was lucky enough to be part of it. It was Frank

Vignola, Janis Siegel, and just a bunch of guys. And he was very close with all of us and we all loved him so much, and we all miss him so much that whenever we see each other we still talk about him every time. And it was amazing, I learned so much from him. I mean he just sat back and let me do my thing, which was amazing. And you know he offered guidance when it was needed. But mostly he just really let me be myself, and was opposed to the people who didn't want me to be myself, which I was surrounded with in the beginning.

MR: Because?

JM: Well you know —

MR: You did well in the Thelonious Monk competition.

JM: Yeah.

MR: Is that what brought these people to you who wanted to shape you?

JM: Yeah, definitely. I mean I was a young girl. When I did the competition I was 20. When my first record came out I was 22. So you know I was very green and very naïve, and had this big voice, you know, and so everybody immediately saw all these different kinds of possibilities, and you know it's the nature of the game. You know you come into these situations with managers and record companies and everything, and they see all this potential in you and they want to put their ideas to work with you. And that's really great for a lot of artists, but musically I've always known exactly what I wanted to do and I never needed anyone to tell me. You know everyone's molding really had more to do with how I looked and how I acted and how they presented me with certain musicians, you know, for instance having Kenny Barron, Ron Carter and Lewis Nash play on my first album. Bucky Pizzarelli, you know, Fathead, Hank Crawford. You know it was amazing. And they did that on purpose, specifically so when the record came out the people would realize immediately that I was the real thing and deserved some respect even though I was only 22. You know the message was well if Ron Carter's going to play on the record, you know, she's got to be worth listening to. Because at that time there weren't really any other singers who were that age. I remember seeing in the press somewhere Diana Krall getting some flack about her age at that time, and she was older than I am now. So it was a weird thing, surrounding me by those guys, positioning me a certain way, making me look a little older with the evening gowns and the make-up and all of that. You know it all worked together to make people notice me and give a listen.

MR: Did you meet those musicians before the session?

JM: I met them — well I had met some of them before just from being a musician and being around and stuff like that, but mostly it was at the rehearsal for the record. We had one quick little rehearsal. I mean we made that record like this [snaps fingers], I mean we made it so fast. It was very old school. That's the way Joel liked to work. We did

everything live. I still work that way now because I learned it from him, that it's better to just play for real and get a good performance. You know, that's how I sort of grew up in the record making industry, was doing everything the old way.

MR: Well for that record, you signed a contract with this company, was it for a certain number of recordings, was it a one-shot deal sort of?

JM: Yeah as I recall it was pretty much your basic contract, you know, you do an album and then you have like options after that, like five options or so. You know I've never been too — I've got a very good lawyer. He handles it. I know a little bit about that side of things, as much as I really need to know, but mostly I focus on music and you know, just being really involved with the planning and imaging and touring and all of that sort of stuff that happens. I'm involved with all of it now but I wasn't back then.

MR: Okay. That was sort of my next question, you have to have a lawyer to sort of look at contracts.

JM: Oh yeah.

MR: And don't fall into that classic trap of — there was decades of musicians being taken advantage of.

JM: Oh yeah, yeah — no. I've never been taken advantage of, luckily. Never.

MR: Do record sales have an impact on how much money you make?

JM: As a jazz musician on my level no, not at all. We make our money on the road. If you are a big star with just amazing success, you know, a Harry Connick Jr. or a Diana Krall, and your records are going platinum and you have this amazing fan base that just supports you no matter what, then you're going to make some money off your records, yeah. And if you've got publishing too.

MR: Oh, right.

JM: But I don't.

MR: Is that because they are in the position where they can have it in their contact with the record company that they will get a percentage of sales or something like that?

JM: Well yeah, after the record recoups.

MR: Oh right.

JM: Yeah. That'll be part of you contract, part of anyone's contract. But it's hard to recoup on an expensive jazz record, when people aren't really buying CDs that often. I mean we sell them more on the road now because people aren't buying them in the stores anymore, they're downloading them from iTunes, and they'll buy one on the road because they want you to sign it. You know I'll sit there and talk with everybody and sign the records and hang out. I love talking to the crowd after the shows. I mean it's nice. I get to thank everybody. It's a nice thing. But yeah, we'll sell records at the show for that reason. So

it's hard to recoup, we're not selling — you know nobody's selling a ton of records right now. The pop stars are selling less than they ever did.

MR: Do you see figures on on-line sales? I mean does the record company provide you with that kind of information if you want it?

JM: If I wanted them absolutely, yeah. I mean I've looked at that stuff before. Most of the time I don't really. I focus on my end of the job, which is putting on a really good show, maintaining a healthy instrument, and just being involved in all the day to day little things. You know, do you want to take this gig or do you want this tour to run this way or do you want to be on a bill with this person or do this special event or this charity event, all that kind of stuff I'm handling every day and being involved with, as well as my husband, who has a huge role in all of that stuff.

MR: So you and Rick —

JM: We're a team.

MR: You're a team in that. And do you have an agent?

JM: Um hum.

MR: And you correspond with the agent, and the agent may call you up and say look do you want to go to Ft. Lauderdale, they're offering this — I mean do you get into that nitty gritty?

JM: Yeah. I do that with my manager, and we do that with pretty much every show. You know everything is run by me and we figure everything out together, which is great. Especially now because I have a 2-year-old that travels with us, and it'll be the kind of thing like well you know there might not be money for Jack's plane ticket on this trip do you still want to take it, but if we connect it to this gig then it will work out and can your parents watch him during that time. You know, it's like those kind of details. Because Jack comes with us everywhere.

MR: Wow.

JM: The only time he doesn't come on the road is if it's someplace that might be a little dangerous for him or something like last month I went to Palermo for one day — well it was for a couple of days but it was for one gig — so I wasn't going to subject him to the time change. But yeah I'm involved in that kind of stuff every day with the management. The agent calls the manager, the manager calls me, and we do everything and then she goes back to the agent and he books. You know it's that kind of thing.

MR: How have things changed for you, getting back to the recordings now, you're listed as, you've got a new one coming out that you're listed as producer.

JM: Yes.

MR: So that kind of thing doesn't happen overnight.

JM: No it did not. It took ten years, although I co-produced my Christmas album, but it was really time. I'm with a new label now, I'm with Emarcy now. I've been in, what is this my fifth label. N-Coded Music, SONY Classical, Epic, Concord and now Emarcy. And a lot of artists change labels frequently. It's fine you know. I mean you fit in different places at different times in your life and it's great. And it doesn't mean anything bad happened at any of those labels, you just, you know, rosters constantly change, and so I'm with Emarcy now. And before I signed with them I knew what record I wanted to make, I went to them — well I didn't, my manager went to them. Managers, they handle all that stuff. Well some artists do but I don't really. I'm behind it but I don't do the day-to-day like making the phone calls and things like that.

MR: Have you been through a number of managers?

JM: Um hum. I'm with Cynthia Herbst at American International Artists right now. I love her. She is an amazing woman. She is the third manager I've been with, fourth if you count my dad taking over for a minute.

MR: Yeah I was wondering about that.

JM: Because he business-managed me for a long time. My father is a brilliant, brilliant businessman. And business-managed me for a minute. Because there's a lot going on. It's not something I really want to handle myself. There's a corporation that all of the funds go through, and it's complicated. For me the personal stuff is enough. I'd rather have the business stuff go through someone who's got a much better brain for that sort of stuff, and he's my father, and he did it for a while. But now I'm being business-managed by my management firm. But yeah, I went to Emarcy, or my manager did, and he said this is the record that Jane wants to make. She will produce it and it will be a standards record with her band, harking back to the first albums, going back to my roots big time, and they said all right, great, let's do it, her way. Awesome. And somebody finally gave me a chance which is great. And that could be for several reasons, you know it could be because I've been around for a long time and made a lot of records. I'm sure that's part of it. It also could be because no one's really selling a ton of records right now and my moment as like this super hot commodity is over with and now I'm just an established touring artist. I'm sure it's for a lot of reasons, but whatever it is it was necessary. Because I don't need anybody to tell me what to do, how to play standards with my band and make a traditional jazz vocal album and tell me how to sing. I don't need that in my life.

MR: Was there a point where — let me rephrase — what had to happen for you to be able to use your band in the studio?

JM: An awful lot. Because I've been arguing for them for years. But you know everybody seems to think that it's going to be a big selling factor if you have a lot of star names on the record. My opinion on that differs. Because I know my audience and I pretty much

believe that with a few exceptions, you know getting a star rhythm section on the album there are going to be names that the people that buy these kind of vocal albums probably won't recognize, and you're going to end up with a band of brilliant, brilliant musicians who maybe aren't that interested in playing with you and you end up getting a record that sounds very nice but isn't as heartfelt, and you know I tour with my band constantly. I have for years. These guys are my brothers. And they are brilliant musicians. And just because they aren't stars in their own right necessarily yet, that's ridiculous to ask me to not play with them on the album. Although, on the other hand, I've been lucky to play with a lot of amazing people, and that's been really cool. But I don't want to go into the studio without my band, it's ridiculous. You know I mean why would I want to do that? But then bringing in special guests to add to our core group is the most brilliant thing ever, and it's amazing, and you're so lucky to be able to do that in the studio. The cool thing about the new record is all the people we brought in are friends, people I've worked with a lot in the past and it was great, and so I wanted to do it again, with the exception of Larry Goldings who plays a tune on the album and is a friend of ours, a friend of the band, but we just hadn't played together before. But you know Mark O'Connor is on the record, John Pizzarelli is on the record, I mean these are huge names that people will recognize, and people who buy my records will recognize them, because I've been on tours with them and recorded with them and done all kinds of stuff with these guys before.

MR: Well those people who go to your concert and buy the thing and want to get it autographed, that's a plus for them too because they're going to get what they just heard.

JM: Exactly, that's the whole point of it. That's the whole point. That's what I tell the crowd in the show every night when I'm telling them about the new record. I say it's been amazing making these great big epic albums with orchestras and the whole thing, and I will do that again because it's really fun, but it was time to do something that even like remotely resembled what we're doing every night on stage. You know people come and buy the record after the show, and I'm sending them home with something that is completely different from what they just heard and I feel a little bit weird about that. And then you know we make these records that I can't play live. So many of the tunes I just don't even play live. And I'll tell the producers that in the studio. I've done it in the past. You know this song is amazing and this is beautiful, but I'm not going to be able to do this live. Like, "Oh yes you can, oh just try." "No it's not going to work, I will never do this live. Most of this record we're not going to be able to do live, I just want you guys to know that." And I've worked with great producers and I will again but I think in the future I'm going to have to insist on co-producing every project. Because I know what's right for me.

MR: Well do you have people telling you, "Oh listen, Jane, just go up in a more pop vein a little bit, try some of these pop tunes and it'll pay off"?

JM: Yeah I've been told that a lot, and luckily I really love pop tunes, you know making the record with Matt Pierson, "Lovers and Dreamers and Me" we did tons of pop repertoire and it was really fun, it was really fun, but I couldn't really play it live. You know, making "Surrender" with Jorge Calandrelli we did sort of Brazilian stuff with a Brazilian pop feel, a lot of ballads and stuff like that, and it was really fun. That record we could play more live, because at the time I had a guitarist and a saxophone player in my band, it was a larger ensemble, but you know stuff like that, it's been really fun doing these projects where we touch on this different repertoire. And for each thing I had the exact right producer for it, and it was cool. But it was time to get back to the core, and for that, it had to be me.

MR: That sounds like a good title for your next record, "it had to be me."

JM: I didn't think of that. You know we agonized over the title too.

MR: I'll bet.

JM: Oh my God it took forever. It usually does, but this one was really like we need a title like today, Jane, what's it going to be? And we ended up just calling it "Home" because that's what it is. That's what it is. It's exactly that.

MR: Are there issues in the music business with any racial issues, gender issues, or generational issues?

JM: Oh constantly but I've been lucky, I've never had to deal with anything. I've been fine. I've never dealt with — the disrespect that I've dealt with has been more about looks and that kind of shallow stuff like that. It's never been anything about race or gender. It's always been whether or not I'm pretty enough sometimes, and that at other times whether or not I'm too pretty. It's been ridiculous.

MR: It's been non-musical issues.

JM: Yeah, those are the problems that I've had. I've never really had problems with the music. The music is the easy part, the fun part. And luckily everybody's off my case about the other stuff now because I just stopped having it. And I'll tell you, having a baby makes you a lot tougher as a human being.

MR: Really?

JM: You know I've got a 2-year-old boy who, I mean he's a little wild child, you know they are. And so when you're a parent you learn strength and you learn to be able to speak your mind in a firm clear way and not take no for an answer, because that's very important for a toddler, you know? So now, any problem I had with that in the past I don't anymore, because I used to be quite the pushover. I mean anything anyone would

say to me I would just be like, "Well, okay," whether I agreed with it or not. I'm not like that anymore boy. No way.

MR: Well that's a good — I guess a good reputation to get — that she knows her business.

JM: I do now.

MR: Yeah.

JM: I mean you're in this business for long enough and you do learn if you have your eyes and your ears open. You've got to. At the end it's just you. All the people around you that you work with will come and go. And it's you. You need to know. You need to be responsible for yourself.

MR: Did having a child affect your instrument?

JM: Yeah. Not while I was pregnant. I sang great when I was pregnant. Even when I was nine months pregnant. I did a gig at Carnegie Hall, at the recital hall at Carnegie, a duo gig with my pianist, maybe a week or ten days before my son was born, just out to here like waddling in flats and just singing, no problem. But the problem is you have this baby in you and it's pressing on your diaphragm and then you have the baby and all the muscles are just kind of like flabby. And you know it takes a while to get your breathing back together and hormonal changes can affect your voices. And I have just recently been going through a period of vocal difficulty, you know my voice gets tired very, very easily. It's been like seeing doctors and coaches and the whole thing, and every singer goes through this at some point and it's very, very common to go through this sort of thing after having a child, especially now that my voice is being used more than ever. Not only are we on the road constantly, and jazz singers sing probably more than anyone else, because we'll do like twelve shows a week. Everyone knows that I want to be on Broadway one day and people always say to me, "Oh, Jane, eight shows a week that's a lot, can you handle it?" And I'm like, "Honey, I do twelve in six days all the time. And I fly with a 2-year-old with me." You know, I'm like, "Please, I can handle it." So we really sing a lot. And something that my brilliant voice teacher Joan Lader said to me recently that I never thought about it, she said for a singer like me a show is very stressful because I change genre constantly, and so it's like several different kinds of singing. It's not just like I'm doing one thing and staying in one place in terms of technique throughout the show, it's constantly changing and she said that can be very stressful. And I never thought about it. So you know, I'm talking to my son all day, I'm singing to him all day, I'm doing two shows at night sometimes, there's sound check or rehearsing, there's always something going on. There's traveling. There's sleep deprivation. So it's a lot, it's a lot. Plus I speak improperly. I'm trying to learn to speak properly and I just can't.

MR: Really. Who told you that?

JM: My voice teacher and it's true. I speak with relatively bad vocal technique. I speak in too low of a voice. I let my voice break. I should be speaking up here clearly like this, but never remember to do it. I never do. I've got to work on that.

MR: When I spoke with — I was lucky enough to get an interview with Nancy Wilson and she said that she just wanted to be known as "a singer." She felt I guess that she'd been typecast as a jazz singer, but that's not how she felt about herself. You on the other hand have said, "I'm a jazz singer." So what makes that? Is it the repertoire you choose?

JM: Well you know what, the definition of what makes a jazz singer now has loosened and expanded so completely. And you know what, I'm a lot of different kinds of singers. I mean there's so much that I love to do. I mean I could call myself a jazz singer. I could call myself a musical theater singer because I can do that too. I could call myself a pop singer because I can do that too. It's just that jazz is really the center. It's what I really grew up doing and it's what suits me the best and it's what I do for a living. I mean I get up on stage with a jazz trio and I improvise and I sing standards, but I like to get outside it too, and we all do. We all do. I mean what was it, Ella recorded like "Sunshine of Your Love" I think.

MR: Oh my.

JM: You know, I think I'm getting that right. I mean Sarah Vaughan did all kinds of stuff. I mean everybody sings The Beatles. Everybody. I mean everybody has been just changing the definition of what that means. It's less about the choice of your song now and more about how you interpret it.

MR: Well that's a good answer. When you go out to do a show does it matter — that's not really the right word — if you know that your show is going to be in a club with a maximum capacity of 125 as opposed to a 2500 theater that you hope to fill, does it change your choice of material?

JM: Nope. Not at all. And It doesn't change the way I conduct myself on stage either. What will change the way I conduct myself is the level of formality. I might be a little bit different at a very formal affair with a full orchestra, say the orchestra is in tuxes and I'm in a gown, I might not be cracking so many jokes and being quite as silly. Because I really like to make people laugh and I try and it often doesn't work but for me the perfect show is if there's some kind of catharsis where everybody laughs and cries. I do, in every show. When they start applauding sometimes I crack up because it's just like you're clapping for us. Or if I'm singing a ballad I'll totally choke up and cry. And I want them to do that too. But yeah, no I really act the same everywhere I go. I didn't used to. I used to think I had to behave a certain way and be really fake and say certain things and be this image of this perfect jazz princess, and I cut that loose a while ago.

MR: Well I noticed your relationship with the audience, I saw you perform at The Other Side in Utica, which was 60 people maximum almost, and it was nice, it was homey, and I cracked up when someone asked you a question about a song and you said, "Wait a minute" and you whipped out your —

JM: Oh my iPhone. I've done that in clubs. I've been like I really want to sing this but I can't remember the words. I swear I know the melody to like seven thousand songs and I don't know the words to any of them. So I will pull out my phone and read lyrics. I've done it. I mean I wouldn't do it at a big fancy gig, but in a little club where everything is super loose, loose enough that I can wear jeans, I'll pull out my phone.

MR: Okay. If it's a jean gig out comes the phone.

JM: But only for lyrics on a tune that I really really want to do or if it's something somebody requested, or I'll have my phone on stage for New Year's Eve gigs so I know when it's going to be midnight, and otherwise no.

MR: Oh right, you don't want to miss the ball coming down.

JM: No that wouldn't be good.

MR: Have you been in a position where you have a bunch of young aspiring singers asking you questions, like how to do I get — what they basically want is they want to get where you're at.

JM: Yeah people ask me all the time. And you know it's hard because I had a lucky break. I mean I was playing gigs in Manhattan and doing all of that for several years before the Monk competition, but then I did it and I had a break. It's really hard to get noticed. It's really hard. Because it's not like head honchos of record companies are going and sitting in the little jazz club with their cigar just waiting to discover the next big thing. That doesn't happen. So it's hard. So I always tell people to watch for opportunities like the Monk competition. Or Tanglewood does a thing where they choose four people to perform in a small venue at the festival and I was one of the judges for that this year. You know, things like that can really help. And now there's things like, what is it called, Sonicbids, the website, where you can put up your demo and your bio and all this kind of stuff and try to get gigs that way. You know the Internet is amazing for helping yourself get established as a musician. I mean look at all the people now who are huge pop stars or rock bands or things like that that have become stars because of the Internet, because of MySpace and FaceBook and all of that. So utilizing that it key.

MR: It's interesting, Eric Alexander said — I think he placed second in the Thelonious Monk competition also, behind Joshua Redman. And he said six months later he was working in a cubicle selling medical supplies or something. Like he didn't have that — whatever happened for you did not necessarily happen for him. Maybe it's different for vocalists.

JM: It's different when you are a super young vocalist. And what happened that year sort of got a lot of press too, because they changed the age limit and so the winner of the competition, Terry Thornton, was over 40 years older than I was. She was first and I was second. She was over sixty and I was twenty. So that big gap got a lot of attention. And plus I got up there and I was really confident and I had, you know, charts for the guys and was an experienced musician and had no problem doing what I was doing and just did it. At twenty. People were — you know I didn't think there was anything weird about that, I mean I came from a bunch of musicians who were that age, you know, I'm doing my job. And then when people were surprised that I could do my job I was surprised. And I think that's why I kind of got some attention because everyone was just like, "What is she doing? Why does she know this stuff?"

MR: Well thank you for leading into my next question. What do you think singers should be able to convey to their band?

JM: Everything. Unless you want to have a musical director who you need to be able to communicate clearly with, and a lot of singers choose to do that. I mean I don't have a musical director but my pianist, Michael, he does a lot of the arrangements, he holds on to all the charts for us, my bass player, I should say Michael Kanan. Neil Miner, my bass player, does a lot of arrangements too. My husband, Rick Montalbano, helps out a lot with the tour managing and just doing all the day-to-day business with our management. Everybody has a role. I choose all the tunes but you know you need to be able to understand the science of music. You've got to understand theory, you've got to know how to write a chart, you've got to have a decent ear and be able to sing in tune, you've got to know how to pick a tempo that's right for yourself and count off, you've got to know how to communicate to the band what you're looking for out of the tune if you're having someone else do an arrangement for you which is what I always do. You have to be able to tell them what you want in clear terms. And most of all you need to be able to emotionally connect with your band enough that the music you're making has a reason to be there. You need to know what's right for you. You need to be able to choose the musicians that are right for you and be able to tell whether or not they're providing what you need. It's a whole thing, and it comes with experience.

MR: Well how much of that did you learn at the Manhattan School of Music?

JM: I learned a lot there, and really just being in the City. Because you get to New York City and you're in the jazz department, it's a conservatory, and instantly there's a scene you're a part of. And you're going to the clubs every night and singing at the jam sessions and doing all that kind of stuff and hanging out with all the musicians and playing gigs, and yeah you learn that stuff. And if you're paying attention you learn it fast. I did.

MR: This is a hard question, and I haven't had much luck with it in the past anyway, did you ever have any really bad gigs or sort of a traumatic experience that in retrospect you learned from, maybe in those jam session scenes.

JM: Well there was a whole lot of you know, well she's just the singer. You know singers get that. And you know, I never really was too into that. But I never really had any very bad experiences except for being a little bit vibed. Once I started singing people would usually stop vibing me because they realized that I had done my homework, you know what I mean? But yeah I never really had very many bad experiences. When it comes down to music, everything's been great. It's been some of the stuff around it that has been bad experiences in my career. But I've always had wonderful experiences with the music itself.

MR: Well as a sideman, singers can help the sidemen a lot, or they can hinder the whole process. You know that's something I guess you learn through experience.

JM: Um hum. I mean the whole thing has to fit together and be right. It does.

MR: You said an interesting thing about bossa nova music and samba music that I enjoyed. I think you said samba makes everything happy.

JM: It makes everything better. It does. It's healing music. It is. I think so.

MR: So if you take a tune that's normally done as a swing tune and make it into a samba — but you also said you mostly dislike changing tempos or feels for songs. I'm not sure I understood.

JM: Well what I mean by that is that generally I don't like to get too super far away from the composer's original intention because those guys were brilliant, and mostly what I mean by it is when the lyrics are not taken into account. That drives me batty.

MR: Sure, that's easy to do.

JM: Yeah. And it happens constantly on instrumental versions of tunes, and in that case it's all right because we're not hearing the lyrics. But when you say — I don't know I don't want to name any examples but I've got plenty of them in my head of times when there have been like vocal versions of things where you know the lyrics said a certain thing and the arrangement said another. And I can understand interpreting the lyric in a different way and finding a different meaning in the tune, but when the two are just totally divergent I can't stand it.

MR: Yeah. Well you're getting back to what's right for the music.

JM: Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

JM: And I mean do you care — like if Richard Rogers wanted something to be a certain way, who are you to say that it shouldn't be?

MR: Right. Do you have aspirations to write original material?

JM: I'm not really much for songwriting. I used to do tons of it. The way I look at it there are just way too many great songs that I'd want to sing and I couldn't get through them in a lifetime so when am I going to find time to sing something I wrote that's not as good. But I do love to write lyrics. I do. Occasionally I've been given tunes by people to write lyrics to. And actually my first published lyric has just happened. And it's really like the proudest moment of my entire career because it's for one of Ivan Lins tune.

MR: It's what?

JM: It's for an Ivan Lins tune. And I idolize him. His music means everything to me. I sing so many of his tunes. I've recorded four duets with him. Actually the fourth duet is the song. He sent me the song to write the lyrics to and then we recorded this duet for this album. I'm not sure if it's out yet. I don't know what the album is called. I don't know if it's going to be released in the States.

MR: It's his album?

JM: It's his album. It's a big duets album with orchestra. It's like a huge project. But yeah, I'm just beyond excited about it. I can't believe it even happened.

MR: Did he give you any guidance with what he was looking for with the song? Did the song have a title?

JM: No it didn't yet. But he told me. It's a love song. Ivan writes love songs. He either writes love songs or political statements. You know in the great Brazilian tradition. You know a lot of great Brazilian music is very politically minded. I mean you look at a lot of these lyrics and they're, you know — but yeah, it's also the great love songs, and that's what this was.

MR: What about the C word, the critics?

JM: Generally they have more to say about my looks than they do about my music, which drives me nuts. And it goes in both directions. You know I'll have reviews that — I was talking about this in an interview just yesterday. I'll have reviews that focus on how hideous I looked than I sounded; and reviews that focused more on how great I looked than how I sounded. And I disagree with them. I tend to agree with the hideous-sayers. But yeah, it's ridiculous. I mean what, just because I'm a young woman like that you've got to decide to pick that apart? I mean I know it's what we do in this industry. It's what we do. It's part of it. But I feel like what we're doing up there musically is good enough that that should take precedence over what dress I'm wearing and how much the critic liked the way it fit me, or what I did with my hair that night. People go crazy over the fact that my hands are always in my hair. Even just doing this interview right now I have my hands in my hair every second. It's just a habit. It drives them nuts. I have people emailing my management asking me not to do it. I'm just like really, this matters this much?

MR: You know they don't do that with men singers. They don't comment. I mean they might say well Joe Williams that night looked marvelous in his tux. But then that's pretty much it.

JM: Yeah. And instrumentalists never. And I enjoy the dressing up and the glamour and all of that. It's super fun, I mean I love it, it's really fun. But at a certain point though it's like come on, really? This is what you're going to talk about?

MR: Well you know they have to have, I've often thought about critics and so forth, they have to have something to write about. And if they're not really good at — if they're not musicians first, which most of them are not, then it's a little harder to write — it's probably easier to write about how you look than the music part of it.

JM: Yeah. And I mean the visual is important. Everyone is sitting there looking at you and they all have their opinions about it. Although it really does break your heart when somebody insults the way you look. I mean it really hurts. Of course it does. That never goes away. But the worst is when, like one times recently — well no, I hate it more when people insult my looks. That really hurts my feelings a lot. But recently I had someone say that my singing was "ordinary." And that was just so mean that I laughed out loud when I read it. Because what other reaction was I going to have to something that was like that mean, to be called "ordinary." Not like well she's doing something but I don't like it. That's fine. But to be called ordinary. That was — I disagree.

MR: That is rather a low blow.

JM: Yeah but I seriously just started laughing because I couldn't — I mean people have said a lot of bad things about me but they've never just said like eh.

MR: Didn't somebody early on — I don't know if it was very early in your career — someone made some comparison to Ella Fitzgerald with you. And I thought that was so unfair. Like why do you take that off as a starting point.

JM: Yeah it's like come on, I'm 20. I mean she is my idol and was a very strong influence, but everybody has to compare everything to something else. Nothing new comes along without the press telling all the listeners, okay, it's similar to this thing. So if you like that thing you'll like this. If not, look elsewhere. I mean nobody just says okay here's the new person check it out and decide for yourself. That's just not what happens. I mean and there's already, I mean when I first started out I was compared to everybody. And now I see in the press young singers being compared to me, which is funny. A singer, whose name I won't mention, I saw in the press recently was referred to as, "The new Jane Monheit." I'm like I'm still here. I'm only 32. I'm not going away. I don't need a new me.

MR: Well that's sort of what I was wondering about.

JM: Although it's flattering in the same way.

MR. Like with the generational things. I mean it's not a generation, it's what, a decade thing or something.

JM: Well there is constant turnover in this business too. We're always looking for the new hot thing. That doesn't mean that the thing that came before goes away. I mean it really was kind of flattering that somebody said that. It was like, "Oh really — you guys noticed me enough that you can say that there's a new me."

MR: Yes like you become a touchtone for something, yeah.

JM: That's actually really cool. Although at the same time I was just kind of a mixed feeling thing. It was like how do I feel about this. I'm not really sure right now.

MR: Was there something specific you really liked about Ella Fitzgerald?

JM: Everything. Everything. I mean she was a great musician and a brilliant improviser, and sang with such sincerity. I mean you believed Ella. She sang completely — I mean there was no artifice. I mean there was this natural, beautiful thing that came out of her and was absolutely truthful at all times. But then, getting older and knowing musicians that played with her and learning about who she was as a person, I like her even more. The musicians loved her. She was a great musician. She knew exactly what she was doing, and everyone has told me that she was the sweetest, sweetest, loveliest person imaginable. And I've met her son, I recorded a song with Ray Brown Junior, and he is the sweetest person imaginable, and I'm just like because your Momma was Ella and I've heard that she was so nice. And it makes me love her even more, knowing that not only that she just knew as much as the guys around her did, but that she had this huge loving heart. But how could she not, the way that she sang.

MR: I'm going to ask you to move your mic off your sweater a little bit.

JM: How's that, is that better?

MR: Yeah. We can cut that out.

JM: So I've read you came from a musical family. You were musical. You married into a musical family. It's like going to definitely be in the genes of your son.

JM: Oh yeah. He's already got his own drumset, two years old, although he'd rather play dad's. He'd much rather play the big drums. And my husband also has a set of electronic drums for practicing quietly and Jack will sit at the drums with the giant earphones on like engulfing his head, and play. It's the cutest thing ever. But he's playing real things that make sense, at two. And my husband could as well. So I'm really proud. And he loves to sing. He sings all day. And he's obsessed with bass right now. Obsessed with bass. He turns everything into a bass.

MR: That's a good thing to be obsessed with. I mean for me the bass starts it all.

JM: And my husband and I, since Jack was born, were like aww wouldn't it be great if he's a bass player, then it would just be like the family band. Dad on drums, Mom singing and baby bass player, grandpa playing the piano. Perfection. It'd be neat.

MR: The critics would love that.

JM: Oh yeah. They already love it when I do a show with my husband and father-in-law, the two of them looking exactly alike, making the same faces when they play, just like swinging their butts off together.

MR: I've noticed that.

JM: It's so great.

MR: Your father-in-law taught me a lot.

JM: He's taught everybody a lot. He's just the heart and soul of the Central NY jazz scene, and has been forever.

MR: Do you envision what goals you should be setting? Or do you set goals, long term?

JM: You know you can't think too long term in this business because everything is changing constantly. I have things that I really want to do. You know I really want to do theater again. I really want to make a big band record. I really want to do more orchestral work. At some point I want to do a record of — you know I mean standards are show tunes, they are, I mean that's how they started. They're from, you know, musicals or from musical films. But I'd like to get more into the actual theatrical side of things and make a record that focused more on that end at some point — you know those are the three things right now that are in my head that I'd like to do. But who knows when I'll do them? I mean making albums like that, those are expensive endeavors, and doing theater, that's just like the right opportunity falls into your lap. I've been very close to it before. I've been almost on Broadway before, but, you know, things happen. You're touring. You're on the road all the time. I would have to do something like that at a time when I could get off the road for six months.

MR: Right. You'd have to plan well ahead. What was it that made you decide that you could move from New York City? I mean you have to travel anyway so is it partly that it doesn't matter as much now where you live?

JM: Yeah it really does, as long as you're near an airport, especially now with email and all the technology. I mean you can record a duet with somebody who's 5,000 miles away. I mean it doesn't matter, we have everything at our fingertips now. I still live part time in New York because I do need to be there a lot. But once we had a baby we were just like, "Let's get out of here." And so we moved upstate, because my husband's whole family is here. And my family is on Long Island, we still see them all the time because we're in the City all the time. It's perfect. And my son has freedom. He has the freedom of here, you know where he can run around outside and our street — we see like one car a day on our

street. It's safe. We live on a lake. He's near the water. I mean it's a beautiful thing for a little boy. And then he's got all the culture of the City when he's a little older. It's going to be the museums and the theater and the clubs that will let him in.

MR: He's going to be worldly.

JM: I'll be like sneaking my son into jazz clubs, you know, to hear music, when he's like 16. It's like, "Okay let's just use a little eyeliner pencil and make a little moustache. We'll say you're 21. You only get to drink root beer but you can hear the music."

MR: So have you ever done an interview and you're sitting there and you're saying gee I wish they would ask me this?

JM: Well I just steer the conversation if there's something I want to talk about. Sometimes you have to. Like if you're promoting a certain project. If the interview has a purpose, you know, if it's promoting a certain thing and the conversation isn't getting there. Sometimes you have to — "Well we do have a show tonight at 8 p.m. at this place." You know, this kind of thing.

MR: Who in the classic rock world have you listened to that you may have liked?

JM: Everybody.

MR: Yeah?

JM: I have not just listened to jazz in my life. So much other music. You know in the car we're more likely to be listening to like Zeppelin, or Jimi Hendrix, or The Beatles or Stevie Wonder or something like that. I grew up on Joni Mitchell and my father is a banjo player. I heard a lot of bluegrass growing up. And you know, for a hot second I considered singing that kind of music. One of my favorite singers on the planet is Maura O'Connell who is a brilliant singer from that genre, a beautiful folk/bluegrass singer. You know I worked a lot with Béla Fleck and Mark O'Connor and her early albums which I just loved. And she was a big influence on me as a singer. You know, so there were so many other influences, and a lot of rock music, I mean a lot. I still love it. I mean and I love pop music.

MR: You love what music?

JM: Pop music.

MR: Oh yeah, sure.

JM: I have so much fun with today's pop music. Because it's a release. Like I'll go to the gym with like Lady Gaga screaming in my headphones, and it makes the treadmill fun. There is something to be said for every single genre of music. And people who say, "Oh well I just hate this kind of music and won't listen to it." Well then try again, because there's something great about everything.

MR: You and Rick have a very romantic story. You've talked about meeting him and he was pursuing you, and I guess it was a mutual pursuance.

JM: Oh it was all him. He chased me as I had never been chased by a boy. Oh yeah, just chased. Although it's not like I was resisting. We met in college when we were both 20. I was a junior and he was a freshman. He had taken two years off before starting school because he was just playing constantly. He had a thousand gigs. And that's as much of an education for a jazz musician as theory class. Both things are incredibly important. So we met at the beginning of the school year and yeah, that was it, boy, that was it. And now we've been together for 13 years.

MR: Nice. Well I've enjoyed talking to you.

JM: Thank you for having me.

MR: It's been a real pleasure and I'm glad to add you to our list of people that we've spoken to.

JM: Well I've read the list and I am proud to be part of it. Thank you. I really appreciate this.

MR: Okay. Thanks a lot.